Quick Cards

Group Openers and Closers for Adult IOP and PHP

All 120 entries, eight cards per page. Print on US Letter at actual size (or “Fit to printable area” on A4), then cut along the grey lines.

Two rules travel with every card. Always offer the pass. If anything suggests current risk, pause and follow your program’s protocol.

Cards marked † have a key caution in the full entry. Read the full entry in the book before you use the card for the first time.

Each card is a one-line reminder, not the full script. The book has the new-member, returning-member, no-writing, and telehealth versions for every entry.

Copying: if you or your program bought the book, your staff may print these cards for use inside your program. Please don’t resell them, post them publicly, or share the file outside your program.

Your opinion matters, whatever it is. If this book has helped your groups, or fell short somewhere, an honest review on Amazon helps other facilitators. Scan the code or go to thoughtkindpress.com/openers/review.

#1 · CHECK-IN

Battery Percentage

If your energy were a phone battery, what percentage are you at right now?

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#2 · CHECK-IN

Two-Word Sky Forecast

Give your mood a two-word weather report.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#3 · CHECK-IN

The Threshold Drop

Name one errand or task you are leaving outside the door for this hour.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#4 · CHECK-IN

Three-Mode Arrival

Ready to talk, mostly listening, or just glad I made it into the chair?

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#5 · CHECK-IN

Friction and Flow

One small moment of friction and one small moment of flow from the last 24 hours.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#6 · CHECK-IN

Terrain Underfoot

Flat sidewalk, uphill gravel, deep mud, or steady grass: what has your week felt like underfoot?

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#7 · CHECK-IN

Skill in the Wild

Name one coping tool you used, thought about later, or wish you had used since last group.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#8 · CHECK-IN

Internal Volume Dial

From 1 (quiet) to 10 (blaring), how loud are your thoughts right now?

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#9 · CHECK-IN

Unseen Effort Credit

Name one ordinary task from the last day that took more effort than anyone could see.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#10 · CHECK-IN

Four-Value Pick

Steadiness, honesty, connection, or self-care: which one do you want to back up today?

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#11 · CHECK-IN

Texture of the Day

Sandpaper, velvet, static, or smooth: give your day so far a texture word.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#12 · CHECK-IN

Three-Question Hand Poll

Raise a hand or nod if… (three quick questions about the week).

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#13 · CHECK-IN

One Reason I Came

“One reason I came today, big or small, is…”

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#14 · CHECK-IN

Everyday Object Utility

Point to one item within reach and name one way it helps you get through the day.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#15 · CHECK-IN

Pace Preference

Slow and steady, step by step, or keep me moving: what pace does your brain need today?

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#16 · CHECK-IN

Seated Posture Notice

Notice how your body is sitting in the chair: settled, restless, or heavy?

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#17 · CHECK-IN

Easiest Hour So Far

Which hour of today has been the easiest so far?

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#18 · CHECK-IN

Brain Fog or Clear Head

Show 1 to 5 fingers: 1 is foggy, 5 is clear.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#19 · CHECK-IN

Room Lighting

Harsh fluorescent, dim lamp, flickering bulb, or daylight: what lighting matches your mind?

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#20 · CHECK-IN

Fair Self-Talk Stem

"One fair, non-harsh thing I can say about how I handled this week is…"

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#21 · CHECK-IN

Either/Or Warm-Up

Coffee or tea? Morning or night? Then one word for your mood.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#22 · CHECK-IN

Weekend Structure Pick

Over-scheduled, too much empty time, or balanced: which fits your weekend?

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#23 · CHECK-IN

One-Verb Intention

Pick one action verb for this hour: listen, ask, rest, stay, try.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#24 · CHECK-IN † READ THE FULL ENTRY FIRST

Early Warning Sign Spotted

Name one early signal you caught in yourself this week before a feeling got bigger.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#25 · CHECK-IN

Social Space Meter

From 1 (quiet bubble) to 10 (glad to be around people), where are you today?

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#26 · CHECK-IN

Both/And Check-In

Two true things about today, joined by “and.”

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#27 · CHECK-IN

Background Soundtrack

What music matches your inner pace today: slow acoustic, fast drums, or something else?

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#28 · CHECK-IN † READ THE FULL ENTRY FIRST

Yesterday’s Headline

Sum up yesterday as a 3-to-5-word headline.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#29 · CHECK-IN

Why This Chair

One low-stakes reason you picked your seat or screen spot today.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#30 · CHECK-IN

Fact or Story Check

Name one small moment this week when your mind added a story on top of the facts.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#31 · CHECK-IN

Morning as an Animal

If your morning were an animal, which one: sloth, hummingbird, house cat, turtle, or another?

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#32 · CHECK-IN † READ THE FULL ENTRY FIRST

If My Stress Could Talk

“If my stress had a one-sentence request for me today, it would ask for…”

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#33 · CHECK-IN

Day-One or Today Word

New here: one word for walking in. Returning: one word for what has or hasn't shifted.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#34 · CHECK-IN

Universal Hassle Tally

Commute, tech glitches, alarms, or waiting on hold: which hassle won your week?

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#35 · CHECK-IN

Value in Action

Name one value you backed up with a small action this week.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#36 · CHECK-IN

Expecting or Experiencing

One word for how you expected today to feel, one word for how it feels now.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#37 · CHECK-IN

First Sense on the Way In

Name one thing you saw, heard, smelled, or felt on your way into group today.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#38 · CHECK-IN

Support Style Menu

Problem-solving, quiet company, distraction, or space: what support fits you this week?

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#39 · CHECK-IN

Group Norm Priority

Confidentiality, the right to pass, no advice-giving, or shared airtime: which matters most today?

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#40 · CHECK-IN

Something to Look Forward To

"Something small I'm looking forward to in the next two days is…"

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#41 · CHECK-IN

Single-Word Topic Label

One word for the life area that has had your attention this week. No details needed.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#42 · CHECK-IN

Room Thermostat Range

Say a number from 1 (shut down) to 10 (overwhelmed) when I point to you. We'll hear the room's range, no names.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#43 · CHECK-IN

Ten Minutes That Mattered

Name one 10-minute stretch this week that matched what matters to you.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#44 · CHECK-IN † READ THE FULL ENTRY FIRST

Boundary Firmness Scale

From 1 to 10, how easy has it been to protect your time and energy lately?

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#45 · CHECK-IN

Thumb-Position Poll

Thumbs up, sideways, or down for your week so far.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#46 · CHECK-IN

Something Steady Out There

Name one object or spot outside this building that feels steady and predictable.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#47 · CHECK-IN † READ THE FULL ENTRY FIRST

Go-To or Backup Tool

Name your usual stress habit this week, and whether you tried a backup tool.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#48 · CHECK-IN

Word and Silent Echo

Share one mood word. If someone else's word fits you too, nod.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#49 · CHECK-IN

Milestone Marker

Getting oriented, doing the middle work, or getting ready to step down?

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#50 · CHECK-IN

Permission Slip Stem

“For the next hour in this group, I’m giving myself permission to…”

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#51 · GROUNDING START

5-4-3-2-1 Room Countdown

Find 5 things you see, 4 you can touch, 3 you hear, 2 you notice in the air, 1 thing holding you up.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#52 · GROUNDING START

Feet and Seat

Press your feet into the floor. Notice the chair holding your back.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#53 · GROUNDING START † READ THE FULL ENTRY FIRST

Four In, Six Out

Breathe in for 4, out for 6, three times. No holding.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#54 · GROUNDING START

Single-Color Hunt

Pick a color. Find five things that color around you.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#55 · GROUNDING START

Palm Press and Release

Press your palms together for 5 seconds. Let go. Notice the change.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#56 · GROUNDING START

Three-Distance Sound Map

Find the farthest sound, a middle sound, and the closest sound.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#57 · GROUNDING START

Shoulder, Jaw, Brow

Drop your shoulders. Unclench your back teeth. Smooth your forehead.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#58 · GROUNDING START

Alphabet Chain

As a group, name foods (or animals, or cities) from A to Z.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#59 · GROUNDING START

Micro-Detail Study

Look at one small object for 45 seconds as if you have never seen one before.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#60 · GROUNDING START

Gentle Countdown

Count down silently from 20, or from 30 by 2s. No score.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#61 · GROUNDING START

Seated Upper-Body Stretch

Wrist circles, a gentle neck tilt, and an open chest, all from your chair.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#62 · GROUNDING START

Room Perimeter Trace

Let your eyes trace the edges and corners of the room.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#63 · GROUNDING START

Cool and Warm

Touch something cool, then something warm. Notice the difference.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#64 · GROUNDING START

Alternating Knee Tap

Tap left knee, right knee, slow and steady, at your own pace.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#65 · GROUNDING START

Fact-Only Room Statements

Make five plain-fact sentences about this room. No opinions.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#66 · GROUNDING START

Hand Outline Trace

Slowly trace the outline of one hand with a finger of the other.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#67 · GROUNDING START

Self-Steadying Posture

Choose one steadying posture and stay in it for 30 seconds.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#68 · GROUNDING START

Wide-Angle Gaze

Look at one spot, then let your view widen to both sides of the room.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#69 · GROUNDING START

Seated Heel-to-Toe Press

Lift your heels, set them down. Lift your toes, set them down. Five times.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#70 · GROUNDING START † READ THE FULL ENTRY FIRST

Thoughts on a Conveyor Belt

Picture each busy thought in a box riding past on a slow belt.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#71 · GROUNDING START

Weight in the Hands

Hold something with some weight. Feel it. Set it down. Notice the difference.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#72 · GROUNDING START

Present-Time Orientation

“Today is (name the day). I am in (name this place). For this hour, my only job is to be here.”

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#73 · GROUNDING START

Finger-to-Thumb Ladder

Touch each fingertip to your thumb, forward and back.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#74 · GROUNDING START

Group Count to Ten

Count to 10 as a group, one voice at a time, no order. Two at once? Pause, breathe, keep going.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#75 · GROUNDING START

Slow Line Draw

Draw one slow, looping line for 30 seconds without lifting your hand.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#76 · GROUNDING START

Spot the Change

Study a few objects for 10 seconds. One moves behind a folder. Can the group spot the change?

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#77 · GROUNDING START

Open Palms Reset

Rest your hands open, palms up, for 45 seconds.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#78 · GROUNDING START

Five-Word Group Memory

Hear five everyday words, rest quietly, then recall them together as a team.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#79 · GROUNDING START

Three-Anchor Sampler

Try sound, feet, and sight for 15 seconds each. Pick your favorite.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#80 · GROUNDING START

Single-Tone Fade

Listen to one tone until you can’t hear it anymore.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#81 · CLOSING

One Word Taking With Me

One word for what you're taking out the door today.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#82 · CLOSING

Keep, Shelf, or Leave Here

Today's main idea: keep it this week, shelf it for later, or leave it here?

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#83 · CLOSING

Next Two Hours Anchor

Name one ordinary thing you'll do in the two hours after group.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#84 · CLOSING

Before-and-After Shift

Two stress numbers, 1 (calm) to 10 (very stressed): when you walked in, and now.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#85 · CLOSING † READ THE FULL ENTRY FIRST

The Vault

Picture setting today's heavy material in a locked vault here until next time.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#86 · CLOSING

Smallest Possible Step

What is the two-minute version of today's skill you'd try before next group?

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#87 · CLOSING

Something I Heard Today

Name one thing someone else said today that stuck with you. No names needed.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#88 · CLOSING

Three Bright or Solid Things

Together, name something bright, something solid, and a color you like in this room.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#89 · CLOSING

Weekend Cornerstone Slot

Name the hardest open block of your weekend and one steady thing to put there.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#90 · CLOSING

What Worked Hard Today

“One part of me that worked hard today was…”

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#91 · CLOSING † READ THE FULL ENTRY FIRST

Witnessed Well-Wish Round

On a last day, if the person leaving agreed: anyone can offer a short well-wish. The person leaving just receives.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#92 · CLOSING

Leaving Behind, Carrying Forward

One thought you’re leaving in this room, one reminder you’re carrying out.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#93 · CLOSING

Twenty-Second Shake-Off

Shake out your hands, wrists, and ankles for 20 seconds.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#94 · CLOSING † READ THE FULL ENTRY FIRST

Note to Tonight’s Self

“If tonight feels long, the one sentence I want to remember is…”

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#95 · CLOSING

One-Word Room Credit

One word for how this group showed up for each other today.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#96 · CLOSING

Values Steering Check-Out

Name one value you want to steer by until the next program day.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#97 · CLOSING † READ THE FULL ENTRY FIRST

Two-Tier Support Check

One thing you can do on your own, one person or place you can turn to.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#98 · CLOSING

Advice to a Day-One Peer

Share one practical tip you wish you had known on your first day here.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#99 · CLOSING

Evening Mode Pick

Rest, gentle tasks, or time with people: which mode do you need tonight?

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#100 · CLOSING † READ THE FULL ENTRY FIRST

Three Bookend Breaths

Three slow breaths together to close today's work.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#101 · CLOSING † READ THE FULL ENTRY FIRST

Obstacle and Plan B

One thing that could get in the way tonight, and your simplest backup move.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#102 · CLOSING † READ THE FULL ENTRY FIRST

Arrivals and Departures

Newest member and departing member each answer one line. Everyone else adds a word.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#103 · CLOSING

Demand Trim

Name one demand tonight you can postpone, hand off, shrink, or drop.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#104 · CLOSING

Sensory Wind-Down Plan

Name one comfort for your senses you'll use tonight.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#105 · CLOSING

Simultaneous Word Waterfall

On the count of three, everyone says (or sends) one word for how they want the rest of the day to feel, all at once.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#106 · CLOSING

What Stood Out Stem

"One idea from today that made me think differently is…"

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#107 · CLOSING

Grounded Stand-Up

Feel your feet, then stand slowly or stay seated. Pause before walking out.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#108 · CLOSING

Everyday Cue Pairing

Pick one everyday object outside this room that will remind you of today's skill.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#109 · CLOSING

Shared Humanity Stem

"Today reminded me that I'm not the only person who…"

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#110 · CLOSING

Notebooks Closed Together

On the cue, close folders, flip papers, cap pens. Today's work is done.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#111 · CLOSING

How I Participated Today

Spoke up, listened closely, practiced a skill, or stayed in the room: which did you do today? All of these count.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#112 · CLOSING

Skill to Keep Practicing

Name one skill you want to keep practicing. No dates or discharge plans needed.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#113 · CLOSING

Ready-to-Try Fingers

1 to 5 fingers: how ready do you feel to try today's skill outside group?

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#114 · CLOSING

Done Today, Waiting for Tomorrow

One thing that's done for today, one thing that can safely wait.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#115 · CLOSING † READ THE FULL ENTRY FIRST

Weekend and Holiday Safety Check-Out

Review the crisis numbers together. Each person names one anchor for the break.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#116 · CLOSING † READ THE FULL ENTRY FIRST

Last-Day Skill Demo

The person leaving teaches one favorite skill in 60 seconds. Everyone tries it.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#117 · CLOSING

Voice-and-Pace Downshift

Facilitator slows down and quiets down. Notice the chair, the floor, the sounds.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#118 · CLOSING † READ THE FULL ENTRY FIRST

One Boundary for Tonight

Name one limit you'll hold tonight to protect your energy.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#119 · CLOSING

Non-Verbal Sign-Off

Wave, nod, thumbs-up, or a chat reaction: pick your goodbye.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.

#120 · CLOSING

Facilitator Continuity Close

The facilitator reads a short, steady close. Members just listen.

Offer the pass. Current risk: pause and follow your protocol.